

## APPENDIX 3: WORLD TRADE ORGANIZATION FACT SHEET

### World Trade Organization (WTO)

**WHEN:** The WTO was created in 1995

**WHAT:** The WTO is a forum for negotiating international trade agreements. It is also the monitoring and regulating body for enforcing these agreements. The WTO works to help producers of goods and services, exporters, and importers conduct their business.

**WHY:** Prior to 1995 international trade was overseen by an organization known as the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT). At a GATT meeting in Uruguay in 1995 the forum created the WTO in the hopes that it would be able to better deal with the complexities of international trade.

**WHO:** 134 member countries including Canada

**How:** The WTO is a forum through which trade agreements are negotiated between the member countries. These agreements set the rules by which various goods and services can move and be traded among participating countries. Once these agreements are signed ratified in parliament, the member countries are then bound to follow the rules set out in the agreements. Should disputes arise, they are appealed to a WTO tribunal for settlement.

**WEBSITE:** [www.wto.org](http://www.wto.org)

**OK, BUT:** As the protests in Seattle made clear, the WTO has many critics. Many see the WTO as an organization that prioritizes trade and commercial considerations over all else. WTO agreements can often override domestic laws, rules, and regulations designed to further worker, consumer, environmental, health, safety, human rights, animal protection. Also, the WTO is not an organization of equals – stronger and richer countries carry more weight in the negotiations and as a result poorer countries are often pushed in directions they may not want to go.

**REFERENCES:** <http://www.zmag.org/ZMag/articles/jan2000albert.htm#WTO>